Contemporary Asian Australian Poets

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Puncher & Wattmann Poetry

The Double Man

Ouyang Yu

my name is
a crystallisation of two cultures
my surname is china
my given name australia
if i translate that direct into english
my surname becomes australia
my given name china
i do not know what motherland means
i possess two countries
or else
i possess neither
my motherland is my past
my motherland is my present
my past motherland is my past
my present motherland is my present
when i go to china
i say i'm returning to my home country
when i go to australia
i say i'm returning to my home country
wherever i go
it is with a heart tinged in two colours
although there is han jian in chinese
there isn't ao jian in english
i write in chinese
like australians do in english
our motherlands have one thing in common:
they've both lost M
i have nullified my home
i have set up a home
in two hundred years' time
i shall be the father of the double man

Note: *han jian*: Chinese traitor; *ao jia*n: Australian traitor.

Some New Perspectives

Ee Tiang Hong

Race, language, religion, birthplace -
the categories do not satisfy:
what do they say of you and me,
the space, the silences between?

Not always negative, I am
more or less than your images,
the truth is always partly,
a few hints here and there.

That's how it is - conceptual
smithereens, in spurts
and starts, a world view,
the twentieth century's, ours.

Translucent Jade

Maureen Ten (Ten Ch'in Ü)

My grandfather made me a gift when I was born.
I used it for a while until another gift, my mother's,
flashed into view. Common in its place of origin, here
her gift sparkled and sang, replaced the other.
Not that his was jostled aside, but it sort of slipped away.
No one seemed to mind, if they noticed, as it lay in disuse
and then was quite forgotten.

Today I retrieved his gift from its silence.
Barely, rarely used, it seemed mostly new.
Pristine. I tried it on.
It was a little strange,
as is from a world I hadn't inhabited but had heard stories about
Sometimes I felt an imposter
Sometimes I thought it reflected hidden aspects I could own.

What vibrations are these?
Does this begin to become me,
Do I to it belong?
This translucent, slowly-yielding music
Chinese name.

My Hakka Grandmother

Eileen Chong

If time could unwind for you
yet be still for me: we would run
through the fields, feet unbound
and pummeling the ground towards

the earth-house. I read about it once:
its architecture unique to the Hakka people
in Fujian. Dwellings like wedding rings
stacked up and interlinked. You would lead me

through the building's single gate
and show me where you slept, above
the communal granary. It would smell
of rice husks, like your dark hair

in the mornings before we'd braid it
long and sleek. I would speak
in your tongue, but we would not need
words. The lines on my palms mirror

yours almost perfectly. I wonder where
our bloodline begins. We are guest people
without land or name, moving south and south,
wild birds seeking a place to call home.

Circular Breathing

Jaya Savige



For Samuel Wagon Watson

There's a man with dreadlocks playing the didgeridoo
in the Piazza di Santa Maria, and everyone is listening.
Kids sit by the fountain swapping smokes for laughs,
tourists lick gelati as they pass illicit markets,
belts, handbags, sunglasses, all made in _____
the place scratched off. Nuns halt, then the Carabinieri,
white gloves, black steel-capped boots glistening.

The crowd hems the young musician in,
Faces glazed with wonder: from where could this
Strange music have come? Surely not this hemisphere.
A drone as deep as unexcavated ruins, far older
Even than the Forum: Armani, Ray-Ban, Dolce
& Gabbana, all sink at once into equivalence.

He doesn't do the kangaroo, the mosquito or
the speeding Holden. Just one dark warm lush hum,
the clean energy of circular breathing, lungs
and instrument the sum, familiar as the accordion
yet strange, as though not for money, nor just for fun,
but for reasons unknowable – some vast, unhurried Om.

I want to bolt up the stairs of the fountain
and claim that sound as the sound of my home -
but stop when I recall how rarely I slow to hear
the truer player busking in King George Square.
Memory kinks my measured walk into a lurch.
My stomach fills with fire. Far above cold stars wheel
around the spire of Rome's oldest Christian church.

THIS IS WHERE IT BEGINS

Merlinda Bobis

Once upon a time in Bikol, Pilipino, English —
we tell it over and over again.

Digde ini nagpopoon. Anum na taon ako, siguro lima.
Si Lola nag-iistorya manongod sa parahabon nin kasag
Na nagtatago sa irarom kan kama.

Dito ito nagsisimula. Anim na taon ako, siguro lima.
Si Lola nagkukuwento tungkol sa magnanakaw ng alimango
na nagtatago sa ilalim ng kama.

This is where it begins. I am six years old, perhaps five.
Grandmother is storytelling about the crab-stealer
hiding under the bed. Each story-word crackles
under the ghost's teeth, infernal under my skin. I shiver.

But perhaps this is where it begins.
Grandfather teasing me with that lady in the hills
walking into his dream, each time a different
colour of dress, a different attitude under my skin.
I am bereft of constancy, literal
at six years old, perhaps five.

Or, this is where it begins.
Mother reviewing for her college Spanish exam:
'Ojos.'
'Labios.'
'Manos.'
Suddenly also under my skin, long before I understood
'Eyes': how they conjure ghosts under the bed,
'Lips': how they make ghosts speak,
'Hands': how they cannot be silent.

I remember too Father gesturing, invoking
once upon a time. This is where it begins.
Story, word, gesture
all under my skin. At six years old, perhaps five.

And so this poem is for my father, mother,
grandmother, grandfather and all the storytellers,
the conjurers who came before us. They made us shiver
not just over crab-stealers hiding under the bed
or a lady uncertain of her garb. They made us shiver
also over faith, over tenderness.

Or that little tickle when a word hits a hidden
crevice in the ear. Just air
heralding the world or worlds that we think
we dream up alone.

No, storytelling is not lonely,
not as we claim—in our little rooms lit only
by a lamp or a late computer glow.
Between the hand and the pen, or the eye and the screen,
they have never left, they who ‘storytold’ before us,
they who are under our skin.

Perhaps they even conjured us, but not alone.
Storytelling, all our eyes collect into singular seeing,
our lips test one note over and over again,
our hands follow each other’s arc, each sweep of resolve.
Eyes, lips, hands conjoined: the umbilical cord restored.